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TransiFlow: A Python package for performing bifurcation analysis on fluid flow problems

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Summary

Dynamical systems such as those derived from models of fluid flows show transition behavior associated with fluid flow instabilities (Wubs & Dijkstra, 2023). Examples are dynamical systems from ocean models in which transition behavior is caused by slow changes in parameters representing the surface forcing (Westen et al., 2024). Such changes in the stability of the fluid flow can be studied by performing numerical simulations with a model and observing its transient behavior after a certain time. This is, however, computationally very expensive, and in many cases infeasible. Instead, so called continuation methods are able to trace stable and unstable steady states in parameter space, obviating expensive transient simulations (Dijkstra, 2005). The `TransiFlow` Python package implements a continuation framework in which fluid flow problems can be studied with the help of several computational back-ends that can, based on the needs of the user, easily be switched between.

One motivation behind `TransiFlow` is that writing research software that works efficiently on a parallel computer is a challenging task. Therefore, numerical models are often developed as a sequential code with parallelization as an afterthought, which makes them very difficult to parallelize, or as a parallel code from the start, which makes them complicated to work with for researchers. This is especially problematic since people that work with these codes generally only work with them for the duration of their project. If there is insufficient continuity between the projects, knowledge of how to use the codes or work on them may get lost, which renders the developed software useless.

In climate modelling, this is a prominent issue, since the models are complex, are usually intercoupled with other models (e.g., ocean, atmosphere, ice), take a very long time to run (i.e., multiple months) and require large amounts of parallelism to reach a sufficient resolution (i.e., using thousands of cores for a single run) (Mulder et al., 2021; Thies et al., 2009). Therefore, ease of developing and using the parallel software is crucial.

By abstracting away the computational back-end from the user, the user can adjust a model to their own needs on their own machine (e.g., a laptop) in Python using the SciPy back-end, and once the model works, run a large scale simulation on a supercomputer, e.g., using the `Trilinos` back-end, which can use a combination of OpenMP, MPI and potentially GPUs, without requiring any changes to the code. The computationally expensive parts of the program are implemented by these libraries, so one does not have to worry about the efficiency of the Python implementation of the model. Initial tests indicate that the overhead of using Python is less than 1% of the total computational cost.

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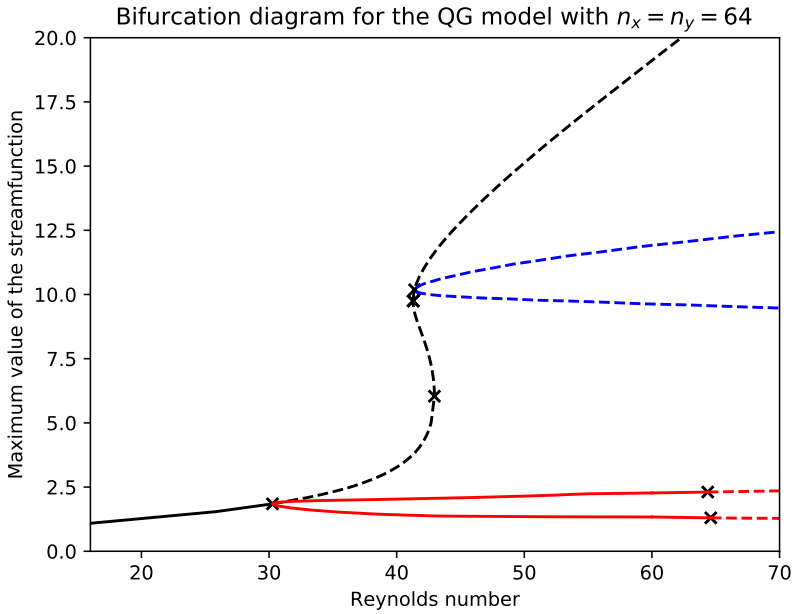

Figure 1: Bifurcation diagram of the double-gyre wind-driven circulation configuration that is included in `TransiFlow`. The markers indicate pitchfork, Hopf and saddle-node bifurcations that were automatically detected by the software. Solid lines indicate stable steady states of the system, dashed lines indicate unstable steady states.

Statement of need

`TransiFlow` aims to be an easy to use tool for performing bifurcation analysis on fluid flow problems that can be used in combination with fast parallel solvers without any additional effort. For this purpose, `TransiFlow` implements pseudo-arclength continuation and implicit time integration methods, as well as finite-volume discretizations of various canonical fluid flow problems such as a lid-driven and differentially heated cavities, Rayleigh-Bénard convection and Taylor-Couette flow, a feature none of its competitors provide.

The main competitors are `AUTO` (Doedel et al., 2007), `MatCont` (Dhooge et al., 2008) and `pde2path` (Uecker, 2014). These packages are widely used, and they are much more feature complete in terms of bifurcation analysis. They do, however, lack the discretized fluid flow models and parallel solver interfaces that make `TransiFlow` easy to use.

A continuation package that does allow for easy coupling with parallel solvers is the `LOCA` package in `Trilinos` (The Trilinos Project Team, 2024). Using `LOCA`, however, requires a vast knowledge of C++ and any change to the continuation algorithm requires a full stack of C++ templates to be reimplemented. Moreover, `LOCA` has not seen any active development in over 10 years.

An alternative Python package for performing bifurcation analysis is `PyNCT` (Draelants et al., 2015). It is, however, difficult to extend, the latest version of the software is not freely available, and it cannot be used for systems that are not symmetric positive-definite.

Past and ongoing research

`TransiFlow` has been used to generate results in (Wubs & Dijkstra, 2023) and (Bernuzzi et al., 2024) and has been used in courses at Utrecht University and the University of Groningen

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(NL). Earlier versions have also been used to generate results in (Song, 2019) and (Baars et al., 2020). The code is currently being used in various projects at Utrecht University and by several external researchers.

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